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Dr. Kamil Bernaerts

POST-DOCTORAL RESEARCHER IN POLITICAL SCIENCE

Summary

I am an ambitious, critical and collaborative post-doctoral researcher specializing in the relationship between (affective) polarisation and democracy, with broad interest in all forms of political polarisation and conflict. My research examines both how affective polarisation is (not) linked to democratic attitudes, and how democratic institutions shape polarisation dynamics and their consequences for democratic societies. In my dissertation, I combined a theoretical advancement of the concept of polarisation with extensive empirical analysis. As a winner of the prestigious Frank Cass Prize 2023 for best article in *Democratization*, my published work spans polarisation, conflict, institutional design, deliberative democracy, and political violence.

Positions

2025-2027 **Guest professor (10%)**
UHasselt
Course: Introduction to Political Science and Governance (SSW)

2025-2026 **Post-doctoral researcher**
Vrije Universiteit Brussel
Program: Evaluating Democratic Governance in Europe (EDGE)

2021-2025 **PhD candidate**
Vrije Universiteit Brussel & University of Warwick

Education

2021-2025 **PhD in Political Science**
Vrije Universiteit Brussel & University of Warwick
Successful public defence held at VUB on September 15, 2025

Dissertation title: “Friends or Foes: Does polarisation really undermine democracy? Understanding the two-way relationship between polarisation dynamics and the processes and institutions of democratic contestation.”

Supervisors: Didier Caluwaerts (VUB) & Michael Saward (Warwick)

2020-2021 **Master of Science in Political Sciences: European and International Governance**
Vrije Universiteit Brussel

Graduated Summa Cum Laude

2017-2020 **BSc in Social Sciences**
Vrije Universiteit Brussel & Universiteit Gent
Minor Political Science

Graduated Magna Cum Laude

Prizes and awards

I have been awarded the Excellence Award by the Faculty for being the top student in my master's program. Then, I have been awarded an EUTOPIA PhD scholarship to fund my PhD research. In 2024, I have been awarded the Frank Cass Prize for best article featuring in the journal Democratization in 2023.

March 2024	**Frank Cass Prize for Best Article of 2023** Democratization, journal
June 2021	**EUTOPIA Co-tutelle Scholarship for joint PhD Program** EUTOPIA university alliance
June 2021	**Excellence Award** Faculty of Economy and Social Sciences, Vrije Universiteit Brussel

Publications

This overview only includes published or accepted articles, datasets and books.

2026

Bernaerts, K. (2026) Hate, not dislike? Understanding anti-democratic attitudes through a multi-dimensional understanding of affective polarization. *Front. Polit. Sci*. 8:1910557.

Bernaerts, K. (2026). Affect or emotions? Disaggregating affective polarisation to explain support for liberal democracy in Belgium and the United Kingdom. *Political Studies Review* (Online First).

Bernaerts, K. (2026). PhD Summary: Friends or Foes, Does Polarisation Really Undermine Democracy? Understanding the Two-Way Relationship Between Polarisation Dynamics and the Processes and Institutions of Democratic Contestation. *Politics of the Low Countries*, 8(1).

Bernaerts, K.; Caluwaerts, D. (2026) State of the Unions: survey experiment on various forms of polarisation and democratic consequences in Belgium and the UK. *VUB Institutional Data Repository*.

2025

Bernaerts, K.; Caluwaerts, D. (2025) Fight or unite? Exploring the link between consensus institutions, polarization and political violence in 113 democracies over time (1900-2023). *International Political Science Review (*Online First)

Bernaerts, K. (2025) Friends or foes: does polarisation really undermine democracy? VUBPRESS Brussels University Press

2023

Bernaerts, K., Blanckaert, B., & Caluwaerts, D. (2023). Institutional design and polarization. Do consensus democracies fare better in fighting polarization than majoritarian democracies? *Democratization*, 30(2), 153–172.

Caluwaerts, D., **Bernaerts, K**, Kesberg, R., Smets, L. & Spruyt, B., 2023, *Frontiers in Political Science*. 5(1127372).

Articles in draft

Here I list the articles I am currently working on and/or are under review.

2026 **Bernaerts, K.**, Junius, N. (2026) Polarising alone? The relationship between social contact and affective polarisation in Belgium and the UK (under review at *Acta Politica*)

Bernaerts, K., (2026) Rethinking polarisation: how its conflictual origins explain a contested relation with democracy (under review at *Politics of the Low Countries*)

Bernaerts, K., Kavadias, L. (2026) Smarty-pants vs Simpletons? Exploring affective polarisation between education-based groups (working paper)

2023 **Bernaerts, K.,** Matthieu, J., Junius, N. & Caluwaerts, D. (2023). Beyond the culture wars? Assessing the socio-economic determinants of affective polarization (working paper)

Teaching experience

In this (2025-2026) and the next academic year (2026-2027), I temporarily fill in as guest-professor at the UHasselt to teach an introductory course in political science. Before, I have given guest lectures on polarisation and statistics, and supervised multiple bachelor and master theses.

2025-2027 **Guest-professor UHasselt (10%)**
Course: Introduction to Political Science and Governance
Program: Bachelor's in social sciences (UHasselt)

2025-2026 **Bachelor thesis workshop: polarisation and democracy**
Supervision of 3 bachelor theses
Program: Bachelor's in political science (VUB)
Prof. Dr. Didier Caluwaerts & Prof. Dr. Dimokritos Kavadias

2025-2026 **Guest lecture: polarisation and democracy, a complicated relationship**
Course: Democratic Theory and Practice
Program: Bachelor's in Social Sciences (VUB)
Prof. Dr. Eline Severs

2024-2025 **Bachelor thesis workshop: polarisation and democracy**
Supervision of 4 bachelor theses
Program: Bachelor's in political science (VUB)
Prof. Dr. Silvia Erzeel

2023-2024 **Bachelor thesis workshop: polarisation and democracy**
Supervision of 5 bachelor theses
Program: Bachelor's in political science (VUB)
Prof. Dr. Silvia Erzeel

2023-2024 **Guest lecture: exploring quantitative research methods**
Course: Research methodology
Program: Master's in political science (VUB)
Prof. Dr. Vjosa Musliu

2022-2023 **Bachelor thesis workshop: polarisation and democracy**
Supervision of 5 bachelor theses
Program: Bachelor's in political science (VUB)

Prof. Dr. Dimokritos Kavadias

2022-2023 **Guest lecture: polarisation and democracy**
Course: Challenges to Democracy
Program: Master's in political science (VUB)
Prof. Dr. Didier Caluwaerts

Presentations

I have presented working papers in >10 international academic conferences or workshops.

2026 **Difference in appreciation and appreciation of differences? Exploring the relationship between political solidarity, affective polarisation, and democratic sentiment**
Presentation at Politicologenetmaal (Ghent)

Polarising alone? The relationship between social contact and affective polarisation in Belgium and the UK
Presentation at State of the Federation (Antwerp)

2025 **Friends or Foes: Does polarisation really undermine democracy? Understanding the two-way relationship between polarisation dynamics and the processes and institutions of democratic contestation**
PhD defence presentation (VUB)

The Polarisation Paradox? Retheorizing Political Division in Democracy
Presentation at the Political Studies Association Conference (Birmingham)

2024 **"Your liberty ends where mine begins". Which forms of polarisation lead to political intolerance?**
Presentation at State of the Federation (Liège)

2023 **"Your liberty ends where mine begins". Which forms of polarisation lead to political intolerance?**
Presentation at WVS Conference: (De)polarisation in values, attitudes & beliefs (London)

Polarising alone? Exploring Social Capital's Mitigating Effect on Polarisation
Presentation at International Conference of Europeanists: Europe's past, present and future (Reykjavik)

Fight or Unite? How Satisfaction with Democracy Moderates the Relationship between Affective Polarization and Support for Political Violence
Presentation at International Conference of Europeanists: Europe's past, present and future (Reykjavik)

Divided we fall? How polarization shapes (anti-)democratic process preferences
Presentation at ECPR General Conference (Prague)

Democracy: still the only game in town? Unpacking polarisation's influence on democratic, autocratic and technocratic preferences
Presentation at Politicologenetmaal (Maastricht)

Fight or unite? A global view on how institutions moderate the link between affective polarization and political violence
Presentation at MPSA Conference (Chicago)

2022 **Polarisation: to feel or not to feel?**
Presentation at Filolab Polarization and Social Change Summer School (Granada)

Hot or cold? Disentangling the concept of polarisation
Presentation at ECPR General Conference (Innsbruck)

Navigating the cobweb: toward a conceptual typology of polarisation
Presentation at State of the Politicologenetmaal (Nijmegen)

Fight or unite? How democratic institutions moderate the link between polarization and political violence
Presentation at State of the Federation Conference (Brussels)

Beyond the culture wars? Assessing the socio-economic determinants of affective polarization
Presentation at State of the NORFACE GOVERNANCE Mid-Term Conference (Vienna)

2021 **Institutional design and polarisation: do consensus democracies fare better in fighting polarisation?**
Presentation at State of the Federation Conference (online)

Professional service

2026-2027 **Academic workshop co-organizer**
Co-organizing a planned international workshop "The end of affective polarization?" at the Brussels Institute for Advanced Studies (BrIAS)

2026 **Jury member Daniël Heinsius Prize for best Master Thesis**
Organized by the VPW and NKWP

2025 **Academic workshop co-organizer**
Co-organized international workshop "Polarising Performances or Re-engaging the Audience?" at University of Warwick

2024 **Panel chair**
World Values Conference on (De)polarisation in values, attitudes & beliefs: comparative perspectives, King's College London

2022 **Panel chair**
ECPR General Conference, University of Innsbruck

2022-2025 **Peer review**
Frontiers in Political Science
Perspectives on Politics
Acta Politica
Social Science Quarterly
Social Inclusion
European Journal of Political Research
European Political Science Review
Nature Human Behaviour
Political Behavior

Community service

2026	**Personal blog** At my personal website, I write blog articles about my research or matters of interest related to my research for a wider audience. One of these articles was republished by the Hannah Arendt Instituut.
2023- 2026	**VUB PACT School Tour** For the VUB-organized Pauwels Academy of Critical Thinking (PACT) school tour, I give lectures in secondary schools in Flanders on polarisation and democracy.
2022-2024	**Political Science and Sociology Junior Talks** Co-organizer of a bridging organisation between the departments of political science and sociology which held weekly seminars where junior researchers could present their work across the disciplines.
2022-2025	**Public lectures and debates** In my role as researcher connected to the valorisation organisation the Hannah Arendt Institute, I have given 10 presentations to the broader public in schools, public events and public debates. I have built a trusted expert status and am still asked regularly to give debates.
2022-2024	**Media occurrences** The article "Institutional design and polarization. Do consensus democracies fare better in fighting polarization than majoritarian democracies?" has been featured in Belgian media such as Knack, Het Laatste Nieuws, RTBF and Bruzz.

Languages

Dutch	Native language
English	Proficient

Relevant research skills

Analysis	5 years of experience (self-taught) in R for own research purposes, limited experience in SPSS and Stata
Data-collection	Scripted and fielded my own survey experiment of 2000 respondents in Belgium and the UK for my PhD research project.

References

Didier Caluwaerts	Associate professor, DFUTURE, Vrije Universiteit Brussel didier.caluwaerts@vub.be
Michael Saward	Full professor, PAIS, University of Warwick m.j.saward@warwick.ac.uk
Nino Junius	FWO post-doc fellow, DFUTURE, Vrije Universiteit Brussel nino.junius@vub.be